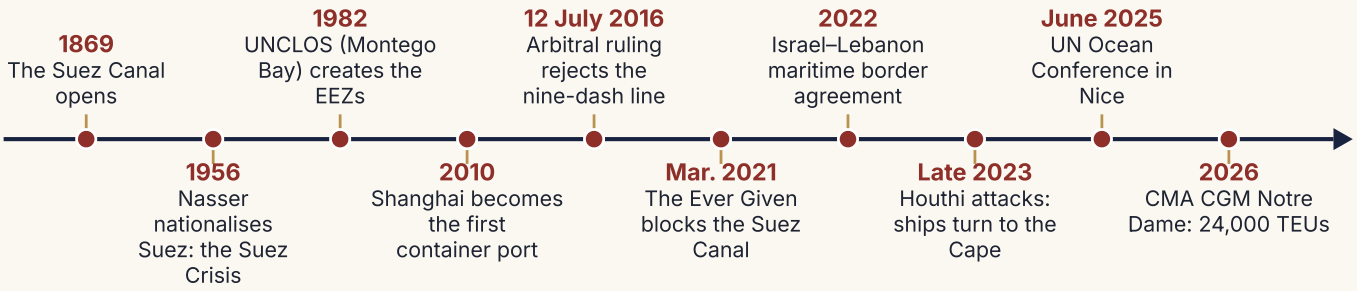
DNL HISTORY-GEOGRAPHY · TERMINALE BFI

G1 Maritime Areas and Geopolitics at the Heart of a Globalised World

Theme 1 — Maritime Areas and Geopolitics at the Heart of a Globalised World

Objective. Assess how far maritimisation organises the global economy; explain why maritime areas — EEZs, choke points, the high seas, the new Arctic routes, the South China Sea — have become strategic and contested; and judge what makes France a great maritime power.

Ten dates to know



The big picture

Globalisation is maritime: 80% of world trade by volume travels by sea, in ever bigger container ships run by a handful of companies, between the ports of the three centres of the global economy — East Asia first. This maritimisation reshapes coasts, value chains and the division of labour; it also turns the sea into a reservoir of resources (fish, oil and gas, minerals, energy) and the bed of the Internet's cables. That is why the seas have become geostrategic: the law of the sea gives states EEZs, a few narrow choke points concentrate the world's flows and its risks, and the high seas raise the question of a common, sustainable governance. The melting of the Arctic ice opens new routes — the Northern Sea Route along Russia, the Northwest Passage through Canada, one day the Transpolar Route — that promise shorter journeys and huge resources, but remain cold, costly, risky and contested; they turn a region of cooperation into one of competition between Russia, China and the USA, down to the race for icebreakers and Greenland. Further south, the South China Sea shows how maritime areas become conflict zones: China's nine-dash line against the claims of its neighbours and the 2016 ruling, artificial islands and maritime militia, and a dispute that has become global. Behind it all lies sea power, still dominated by the United States and its bases, but challenged by China. France owes its maritime power to its overseas territories, which give it the second largest EEZ in the world (10.7 million km², 62% in the Pacific), and to a first-rank navy — a nuclear aircraft carrier, nuclear submarines, bases on every ocean and abroad. It has world-class companies (CMA CGM) and shipyards (Saint-Nazaire), but its shipbuilding has declined and its ports remain middle-ranking. Its stakes are to appropriate and extend its EEZ, to secure its maritime space and energy supplies, to modernise its ports and to protect the sea: a great maritime power, between power and fear of decline.

KEY ISSUES

- Assess the main factors affecting maritime trade patterns.
- How far do you agree that the geostrategic importance of maritime areas is a source of international conflict, rather than cooperation?
- How far do you agree that the benefits of the emergence of new maritime routes in the Arctic far outweigh the constraints?
- Examine the reasons for geopolitical tension over maritime areas you have studied.
- Evaluate the importance of maritimisation as a factor in the organisation of the global economy.
- With reference to Britain or France, and other examples you have studied, assess the role of maritime powers in international maritime space.

KEY TERMS

The Arctic · Containerisation · Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZs) · Globalisation · Maritime choke points · Maritime Power

Summary diagram — How maritimisation organises the global economy — and makes it vulnerable

Containerisation
One standard box for ship, truck and train

→

Gigantism
24,000-TEU ships; a few lines (MSC, Maersk, CMA CGM)

→

Hubs and ports
East Asia leads; ports move offshore

→

Value chains
TNCs produce near Asian ports: the NIDL

→

Choke points
Suez, Malacca, Hormuz: blockage, attacks, piracy

→

Rules
EEZs (1982), protected areas, high seas treaty

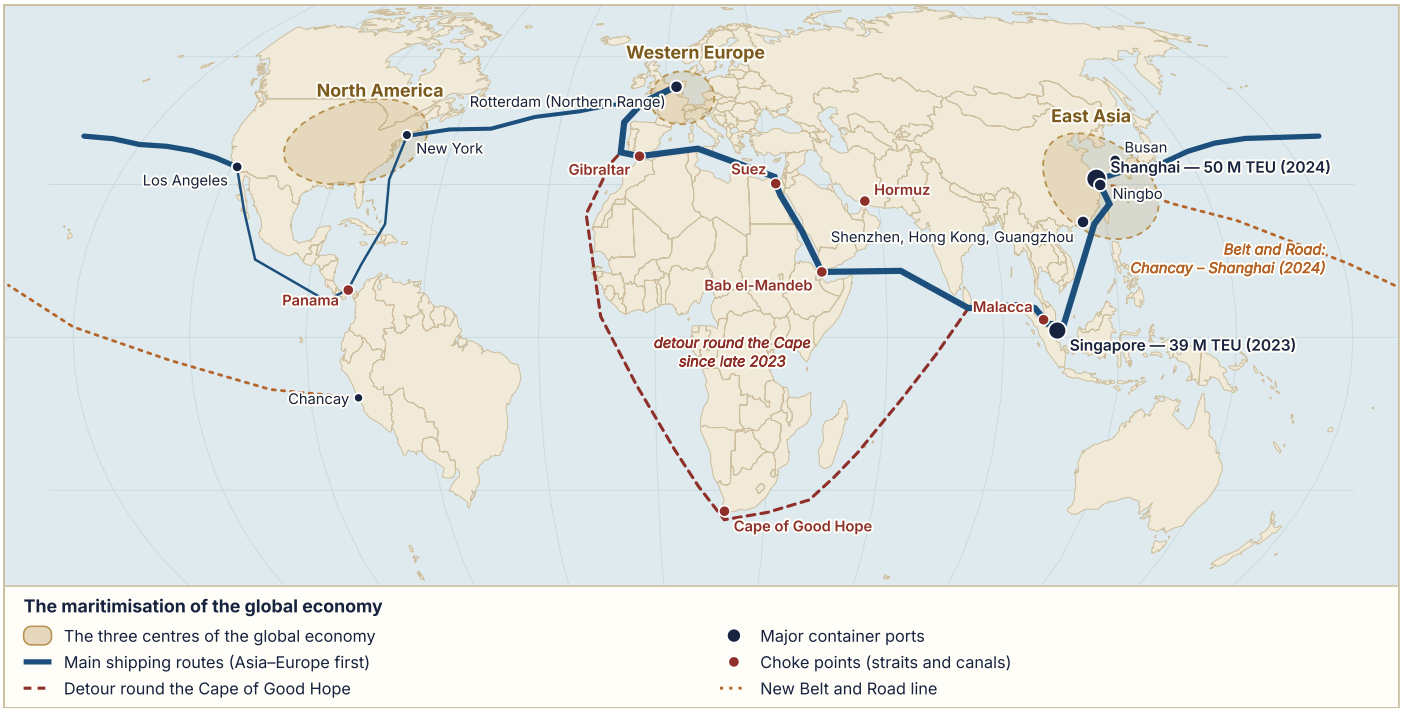
Summary diagram — Maritime areas: a source of conflict or of cooperation?

	Stakes	Sources of tension	Cooperation or settlement
The Arctic	Shorter routes, ores and fuels, development of remote regions	Sovereignty, crime, militarisation; icebreakers; Greenland	Long a region of cooperation and low tensions
Northwest Passage	A short cut instead of the Panama Canal	Canada claims it as Canadian waters	Benefits on paper, constraints in reality (DBQ)
South China Sea	Trade, fish, oil and gas, approaches to China	Nine-dash line, artificial islands, militia (2021)	2016 ruling ignored; the Quad and a "Free and Open Indo-Pacific"
Eastern Mediterranean	Gas fields (Karish, Qana)	Israel and Lebanon, technically at war	2022 agreement on the maritime border

Summary diagram — A great maritime power, between power and fear of decline

	Strengths	Limits
Territory and EEZ	2nd EEZ (10.7 M km²), on every ocean; EXTRAPLAC	Mostly distant territories (97% overseas)
Navy	Nuclear carrier (with the USA only), 4 SSBNs, 5 SSNs, bases abroad	Equipment costly to renew
Merchant navy, shipyards	CMA CGM, 3rd in the world; Saint-Nazaire's cruise ships	Ships under other flags; shipbuilding lost to Asia
Ports	66 ports; Fos 4XL	Marseille 53rd, Le Havre 68th; far from the Northern Range
Economy and resources	2.5% of GDP, 300,000 jobs; 3rd in Europe for fishing	Little offshore oil; marine renewables only 800 jobs
Protection	546 MPAs, 23.5% of waters (2019); Scandola	The 2018 constitutional reform never completed

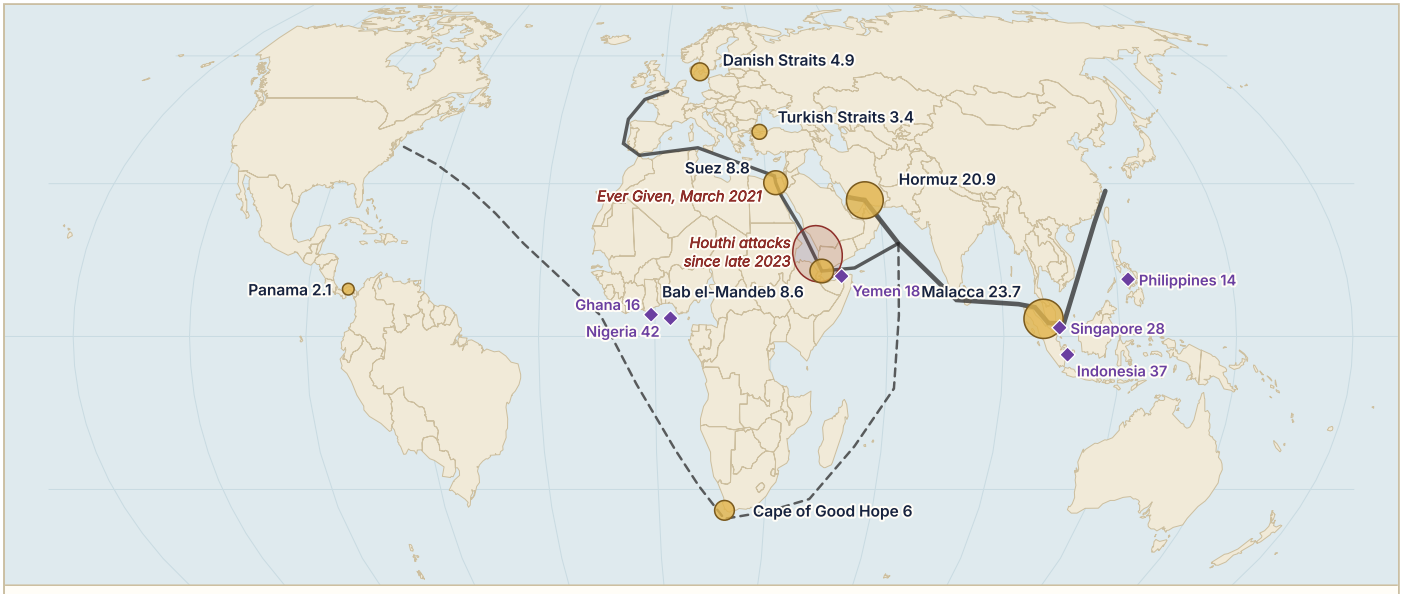
Summary map — The maritimisation of the global economy: centres, routes, ports, choke points



1. Shanghai: first container port since 2010, 50 million TEUs in 2024; Yangshan, offshore and automated.
2. Singapore: second container port, 39 million TEUs (2023), connected to more than 600 ports.
3. Rotterdam and the Northern Range: the first container region until the mid-1990s.
4. FAL 1 (CMA CGM): 105 days, 15 ships, 11 ports of call; to Europe via Suez, back round the Cape.
5. Suez (1869) and Panama (1914): Rotterdam–Singapore 8,440 nautical miles via Suez, 11,940 round the Cape.
6. Chancay (Peru, 2024): a port 60% owned by COSCO, on China's Belt and Road.

Natural Earth base map; routes simplified. The second map shows oil at the choke points and piracy.

Map — Oil and the choke points (2023), attacks and piracy



1. Malacca 23.7 and Hormuz 20.9 million barrels a day (2023); in 2025, Suez fell to 4.9 and the Cape rose to 9.1: the Houthi detour.
2. Malacca: more than 200 ships a day, 29% of seaborne oil, 25% of traded goods; 60% of China's oil.
3. Piracy: 668 incidents in 2011, 375 in 2020; Nigeria, Indonesia, Singapore first; in 2025 South-East Asia leads.

Volumes: U.S. Energy Information Administration; piracy: French Ministry of the Armed Forces and IMB.

Map — The Arctic shipping routes opened by the melting ice



1. Three routes: the Northern Sea Route (along Russia), the Northwest Passage (Canadian archipelago), the Transpolar Sea Route (future).
2. Open only a short time in late summer; expensive icebreakers: Russia at least 50, China 4, Denmark none since 2010.
3. Canada claims the Northwest Passage as Canadian waters; Greenland lies on its route.

Azimuthal polar projection, Natural Earth; routes simplified.

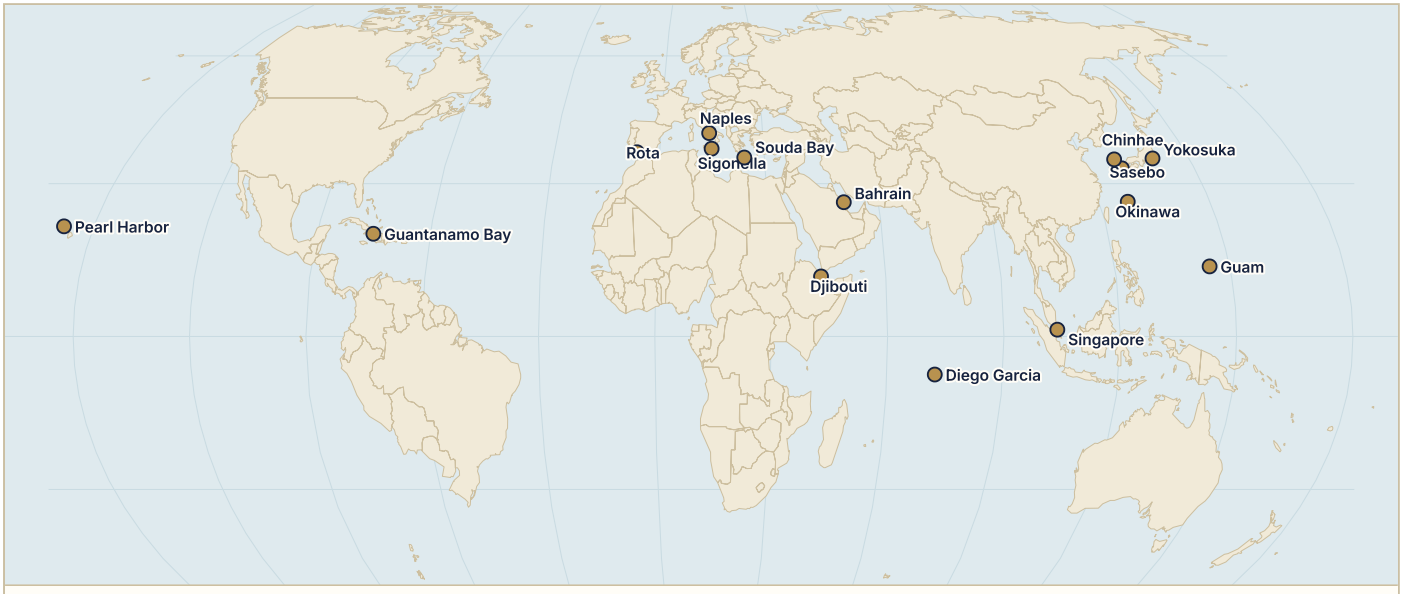
Map — Territorial claims in the South China Sea



1. China's nine-dash line (approximate) against the claims of Vietnam, the Philippines, Malaysia, Brunei and Taiwan.
2. Paracels, Spratlys (Fiery Cross, artificial and militarised), Scarborough Shoal; the 2016 ruling in favour of the Philippines.
3. About 3 million km², more than US$5 trillion of trade a year; five maritime entries lead into it.

Mercator projection, Natural Earth; the nine-dash line is approximate.

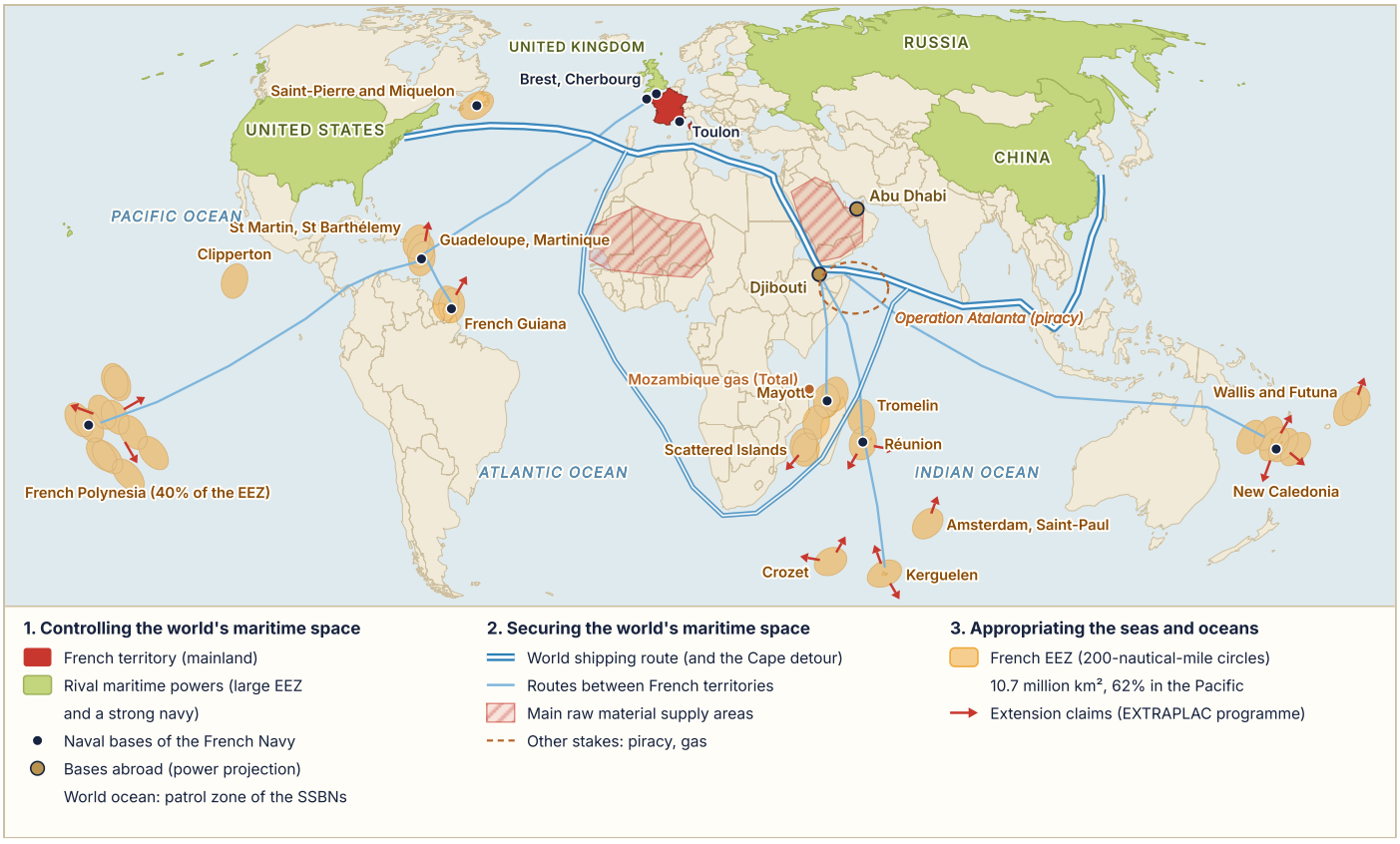
Map — American sea power: the US Navy's forward deployed bases



1. US Navy: 11 aircraft carriers, 66 submarines, 73 destroyers, 340,000 active personnel.
2. Navies by tonnage: USA 3.4 million t, far ahead of Russia, China, Japan, the UK and France.

Main naval bases; Natural Earth base map.

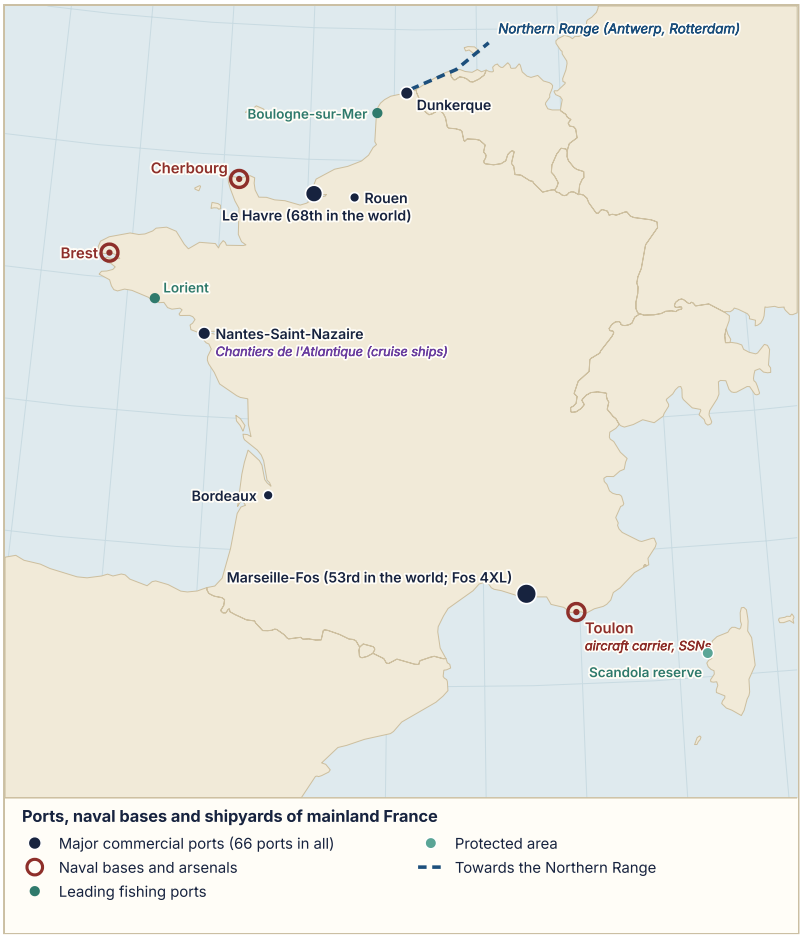
Map — France, a great maritime power



1. EEZ of 10.7 million km², the 2nd in the world: 62% in the Pacific, 40% for French Polynesia alone; 97% of the maritime space is overseas.
2. Bases on every ocean and abroad (Djibouti, Abu Dhabi); a nuclear aircraft carrier, 4 SSBNs, 5 SSNs.
3. EXTRAPLAC: requests to extend the continental shelf; Atalanta against piracy; Total's gas off Mozambique.

After a map by the French Navy and the Ministry for the Overseas (2019); EEZ approximated by 200-nautical-mile circles.

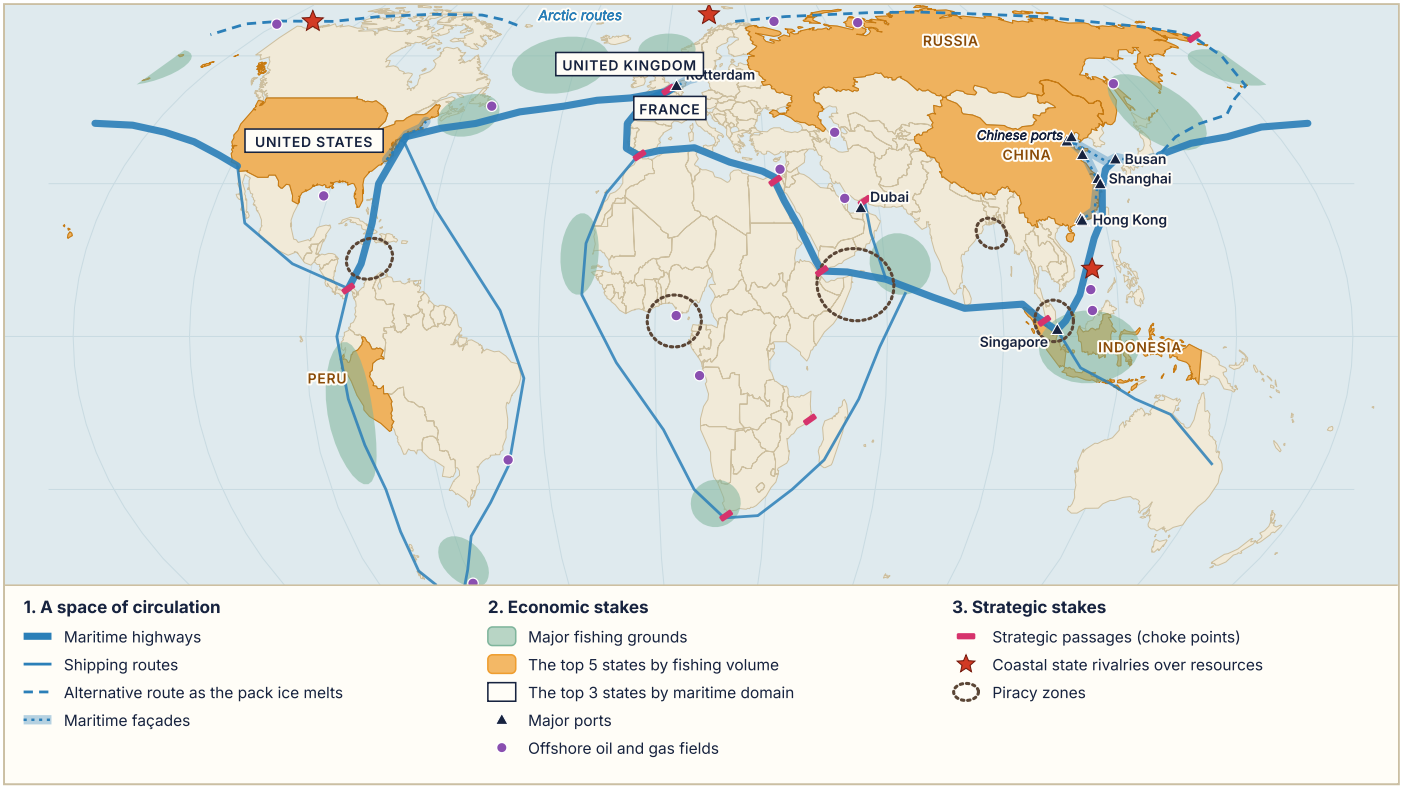
Zoom — Ports, naval bases and shipyards of mainland France



1. 66 ports; Marseille-Fos (Fos 4XL) and Le Havre are only 53rd and 68th in the world; far from the Northern Range.
2. Toulon, the most active arsenal (carrier, SSNs); Brest, Cherbourg; Chantiers de l'Atlantique at Saint-Nazaire.

Natural Earth base map; main fishing ports.

Summary of the theme — Maritime areas in globalisation



1. A ready-made essay plan: 1) a space of circulation, 2) economic stakes, 3) strategic stakes.
2. On the summary map, the top three maritime domains: the United States, the United Kingdom, France.

Summary map of the theme; Arctic routes cut by the edge of the map.

Intro Globalisation: a maritime world

Globalisation is the growing interconnection of people, companies and governments

Globalisation is the process of increased interconnection among people, companies and governments worldwide. This new linkage creates competition between them. It is mainly due to improvements in transportation and communication, and to free trade; it resulted in a sped-up growth of international trade and cultural exchange (key term).

> **EXAMPLE** "Maritime transport is the backbone of global trade and the global economy" (UN Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon, 29 September 2016): the quotation that opens the theme. The photograph that opens it is the port of Pasir Panjang in Singapore (27 December 2024), the second biggest container port in the world.

The seas are both the highway of globalisation and a geopolitical stake

The theme studies maritime areas in five steps: the maritimisation of the global economy (I), the geostrategic importance of maritime areas (II), the emergence of new shipping routes (III), geopolitical conflict in maritime zones (IV) and France as a great maritime power (V). This chapter covers all five parts of the theme.

> **EXAMPLE** Vietnam banned the film Barbie because one of its maps seemed to show China's "nine-dash line", Beijing's claim over most of the South China Sea: even a cartoon map at sea is political. (The ban dates from 2023.)

I.1 Maritimisation of the global economy: transportation and trade

Seaborne trade carries 80% of world trade by volume: there is no alternative

Shipping is the life blood of the global economy. Maritime transportation is dominant because there is no alternative for long-distance transportation of large amounts of freight. Since the 1960s, seaborne trade has increased enormously: it accounts for 80% of world trade by volume. Most goods are shipped on giant vessels connecting the three centres of the global economy: North America, Eastern Asia and Western Europe.

> **EXAMPLE** Goods loaded worldwide rose from about 6 billion tons in 2000 to almost 12 billion in the early 2020s (UNCTAD), with two dips: the 2009 crisis and the Covid-19 pandemic of 2020. Video: "A short history of the Maritime routes" (3 min), and a map of 18th-century British shipping routes drawn from ships' logs (James Cheshire).

A specialised fleet, in which bulk goods weigh most

The world fleet is specialised: container ships, oil tankers, chemical tankers, bulk carriers, liquefied natural gas (LNG) tankers, ro-ro ships (for vehicles) and general cargo ships. In tonnage, raw materials dominate: dry bulk (iron ore, grain, coal) and oil. The rise of the container ship is the great change since 1980.

> **EXAMPLE** Shares of the world fleet capacity (UNCTAD, deadweight tons): oil tankers 50% in 1980, 28% in 2024; dry bulk 27% then 43%; general cargo 17% then 4%; container ships a tiny share in 1980, 14% in 2024.

Containerisation: one standard box for every mode of transport

Containerisation is the increasing use of intermodal freight transport in standard-sized metal boxes (20 ft) which can be transferred from one mode of transport to another — ship, truck, train (key term). Capacity is counted in TEUs (twenty-foot equivalent units): the volume of one 20-ft box, 6.1 m long. The standard box made loading fast and cheap, and it is the base of today's global supply chains.

> **EXAMPLE** The video "A Brief History of Shipping: How a Steel Box Changed the World" (4 min) tells this story. The first container ship sailed in 1956 (the Ideal X of the American trucker Malcolm McLean); containers became widespread in the 1980s.

Gigantism: ever bigger ships on the Asia–Europe route

To cut the cost of each container, ships keep growing. The biggest container carriers carry about 24,000 TEUs and can only sail on the route between China and Europe, the only lane with enough ports able to handle them. On this route Asia, the main manufacturing region, ships manufactured goods, electronics and steel to Europe; Europe exports machinery, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, food and luxury goods to Asia, which is also a major market.

> **EXAMPLE** The CMA CGM Notre Dame (2026): 24,000 TEUs, 399 m long, 61.3 m wide, powered by LNG, built in China by Yangzijiang Shipbuilding, the first of ten sister ships. Longer than four football fields or five Airbus A380s, bigger than the Empire State Building or the Eiffel Tower; a propeller more than 10 m across, an LNG tank that could hold the Statue of Liberty, an engine as powerful as 10 A380 jet engines; its containers would stretch for 141 km end to end (video "Discover the Ship", 4 min). In the 2025 ranking, the ten biggest ship classes all carry 23,000 to 24,346 TEUs (MSC Irina).

A handful of shipping companies control container transport

Container shipping is concentrated in a few giant companies (an oligopoly), European and Asian. They order the giant ships and design the routes. CMA CGM is France's leading container shipping company: it was created in 1978, as a result of a series of mergers, by Jacques Saadé; his son Rodolphe Saadé, chairman and CEO, aims to make it the world's second-largest shipping line by 2027.

> **EXAMPLE** The ten largest container shipping companies in 2026 (TEU capacity, market share): MSC (Switzerland) 6.10 million, 20.1%; Maersk (Denmark) 4.28 million, 14.1%; CMA CGM (France) 3.87 million, 12.7%; COSCO Shipping (China) 3.36 million, 11.1%; then Hapag-Lloyd, ONE, Evergreen, HMM, Yang Ming and ZIM.

The great ports have moved to East Asia

About one container in ten handled worldwide is handled in the ports of the Yangtze River Delta. In East Asia, export-oriented industrialisation policies (Hong Kong, Taiwan, South Korea) sustained the growth of container throughput from the 1980s; China followed in the late 1980s, first in the Pearl River Delta, then in the Yangtze Delta (Shanghai). In the past ten years, Shanghai, Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Qingdao and Ningbo joined Hong Kong, Busan and Singapore as the world's major maritime hubs. Europe's Northern Range was the world's first container region until the mid-1990s, when south China took the lead.

> **EXAMPLE** Shanghai overtook Singapore in 2010 and became, in 2024, the first port in the world to handle 50 million TEUs in a year — the busiest container port for 15 consecutive years. Singapore, connected to more than 600 ports, handled 39 million TEUs in 2023. A 2018 map ranks the container ports in million TEUs: Shanghai 42, Singapore 36.6, Ningbo 26.4, Shenzhen 25.7, Guangzhou 21.9, Busan 21.7, Hong Kong 19.6, Qingdao 19.3, Tianjin 16, Dubai 15 — the first European port, Rotterdam, is only 11th (14.5).

Ports link a hinterland to a foreland, and move offshore to receive the giants

A port connects the continental hinterland (production in factories) and the foreland (overseas markets). Coastal lands are transformed by the growth of seaborne traffic: new deep-water ports are built offshore to keep up with containerised trade. The rising concentration of people and activities on the coasts is the maritimisation of the world; this land use also contributes to environmental degradation.

> **EXAMPLE** Shanghai moved its port from the city centre to the estuary (Waigaoqiao), then offshore to the reclaimed islands of Yangshan, linked to the mainland by the Donghai Bridge, to receive ships with a draft of up to about 16 m. Yangshan is now an automated "smart port", partnered with 22 ports along the Yangtze, 16 of them in the Yangtze River Delta (document study on the Shanghai port terminal; video on the automated wharf of Yangshan, 2025).

Container shipping reshaped global value chains and the division of labour

Seaborne trade connects global value chains: it carries raw materials and semi-processed goods to production hubs and delivers finished products to consumers. Container shipping allowed the global sourcing strategies of transnational corporations (TNCs) and the development of global production networks. It shaped the New International Division of Labour (NIDL): TNCs keep their offices and headquarters in the developed world and often have factories close to the ports of less developed countries, to take advantage of cheaper labour. It resulted in the maritimisation of economies.

> **EXAMPLE** Unilever, H&M and Apple: headquarters in the developed world, production in Asian factories near the ports. China discharges the most seaborne cargo (about 2.6 billion tons in 2023), Australia loads the most (about 1.5 billion tons) (UNCTAD, 2025). (Australia's main seaborne exports are iron ore and coal, much of them bound for China.)

New routes follow the strategies of states: China's Belt and Road

Maritime trade patterns are also shaped by states. China, a "commercial thalassocracy" through the dominance of its port range, integrates its ports into the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) with new routes to foreign ports, to secure its supplies of raw materials and food.

> **EXAMPLE** The port of Chancay in Peru, 60% owned by the Chinese company COSCO, was inaugurated in the presence of Xi Jinping in November 2024. Direct lines to Shanghai and Ningbo-Zhoushan cut sailing times and costs by 20% compared with routes calling in Mexico; they bring iron ore from Peru, lithium from Bolivia, Chile and Argentina, and Peruvian fruit (Géoconfluences, 2025).

I.2 Marine resources

Fisheries feed millions of people, and aquaculture now outweighs wild capture

The fishing sector provides food for millions of people, but overfishing has become a concern: fish stocks are being depleted. Aquaculture (fish farms) is a solution to limit wild captures (capture fisheries). Asia dominates both. Some fishing methods, such as bottom trawling, damage the seabed.

> **EXAMPLE** World fisheries harvest in 2022: China 88.6 million tonnes, of which 75.4 million from aquaculture; Indonesia 22.0 million; India 15.8 million; Vietnam 8.8 million; Peru 5.5 million, almost all wild capture; Russia 5.3 million. Bottom trawling can destroy coral reefs and seabed life, raising sediment plumes visible from space; unwanted fish and marine life can make up 40 to 90% of the bycatch, thrown back into the sea (infographic).

30% of the world's oil and gas comes from offshore fields, ever deeper

30% of world oil and gas production is extracted offshore, and exploration goes on to find new deposits. Production moves into deep water (more than 100 m), which is technically difficult and risky. Offshore fields help states reduce their dependence on imports.

> **EXAMPLE** In March 2025, the China National Offshore Oil Corporation (CNOOC) discovered a 100-million-ton oilfield, Huizhou 19-6, in China's EEZ in the South China Sea. The risk: the explosion of the Deepwater Horizon rig in the Gulf of Mexico on 20 April 2010 killed 11 workers and caused the largest accidental marine oil spill in the world (document study on ocean resources). The main offshore zones on the map of that document study: the Gulf of Mexico, California, Venezuela, south-east Brazil, the Gulf of Guinea, the North Sea, the Caspian Sea and the Persian Gulf, with the Arctic as a potential resource.

The seabed holds minerals and sand, coveted for the green economy and for building

Humans have mined the ocean floor since the 1950s: diamonds, gold, gravel, then (from the 1960s) manganese nodules containing nickel, copper and cobalt. Deep-ocean polymetallic nodules, on the abyssal plains, also hold titanium and rare earth elements: the need for critical metals for high technology and the green-energy economy makes them a target. Sand is a strategic resource too. But dredging destroys marine habitats, and sand extraction causes severe coastal erosion.

> **EXAMPLE** Polymetallic nodules: “an improved understanding of the affected ecosystems … is required before operations begin” (James R. Hein et al., Nature, February 2020). Papua New Guinea is one of the few places where nodules lie in shallow waters.

Marine renewable energies are a potential to develop

The sea is also a source of renewable energy: ocean thermal energy (thermal energy conversion plants), offshore wind (fixed-foundation and floating turbines), tidal energy (tidal turbines) and wave energy (wave energy converters).

> **EXAMPLE** Offshore wind turbines stand between Sweden and Denmark, next to the cruise ships of the Baltic (document study on ocean resources, document 1).

Marine resources are increasingly threatened by human activities

Marine resources are increasingly threatened or destroyed by human activities. The threats are climate change, marine pollution, the extraction of marine resources, and the destruction of marine and coastal habitats and landscapes. Exploiting the sea is therefore also a question of sustainability (see II.3).

> **EXAMPLE** Three threats from the document study on ocean resources: overfishing of wild stocks; dredging for nodules and diamonds, which wipes out fish and invertebrates; oil spills such as Deepwater Horizon (2010).

I.3 Communication and exchanges

The global Internet travels through vulnerable submarine cables

Underwater cables are the fastest and most cost-effective way to transport data across the ocean: the global Internet is made possible by them. They mostly lie on the ocean floor and are buried under the seabed near the shore for protection. They are vulnerable, and their routes avoid dangerous areas. Big tech companies are now the largest investors.

> **EXAMPLE** Meta plans a 50,000-km subsea cable, longer than the Earth's circumference, linking the United States, India, Brazil, South Africa and other regions, up to 7,000 m deep; it avoids the Red Sea, where Houthi rebels attack shipping, and the contested South China Sea. Meta and Google are the largest investors in new cables (ABC News, 19 February 2025).

Cruise tourism is one of the fastest-growing sectors

The sea is also a space of leisure. The cruise industry was badly hit by the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020; fuelled by heavy consumer demand and industry innovation, cruising rebounded faster than international tourism, and cruise capacity keeps growing.

> **EXAMPLE** Two million more people went on cruises in 2023 than in 2019, and demand was predicted to top 35 million passengers in 2024. Share of cruise passengers by region (CLIA, 2023): Caribbean, Bahamas and Bermuda 44.2%; Mediterranean 18.5%; rest of Europe 10.4%; Alaska 5.7%; west coast of North America 5.6%; Asia and China 4.6%. World cruise capacity is forecast to grow by at least 10% from 2024 to 2028.

The seas are also routes for migrants and refugees

Maritime areas carry people as well as goods: for refugees and migrants, the sea is a route — and a dangerous one. The Mediterranean, between Africa, the Middle East and the European Union, is crossed by several migration routes.

> **EXAMPLE** The main sea migration routes in the Mediterranean: the western route (Morocco and Algeria to Spain, through the Strait of Gibraltar), the central route (Libya and Tunisia to Italy and Malta), the eastern route (Turkey to Greece and Cyprus), fed by an East African route.

II.1 Geostrategic importance of maritime areas: exclusive economic zones

An EEZ gives a coastal state the resources of the sea up to 200 nautical miles

Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZs) are bands extending 200 nautical miles from the shore, in which the coastal government has jurisdiction over the exploration and exploitation of marine resources (key term). EEZs were created by the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), signed at Montego Bay (Jamaica). Since 1982, UNCLOS has guided sovereignty over waters: coastal countries have the sole rights to all resources of the waters and the seabed of their EEZ.

> **EXAMPLE** France's EEZ covers about 10.7 million km², 62% of it in the Pacific thanks to its overseas territories (40% for French Polynesia alone): a small territory can command a huge sea. Video: “What is the EEZ: the US case”; exercise: write a simple definition of the EEZ in less than 15 words.

The law of the sea divides the ocean into zones, from full sovereignty to the high seas

UNCLOS distinguishes zones from the baseline (usually the low-water line): territorial waters (12 nautical miles), where sovereignty covers the airspace above and the seabed below; the contiguous zone, where a state controls customs, immigration and other laws; the EEZ (200 nautical miles), where it controls economic resources (fishing, mining, oil) but cannot forbid legal passage; a possible extension over the continental shelf; and beyond, the high seas — international waters, beyond any national jurisdiction.

EXAMPLE A container ship such as the CMA CGM Notre Dame sails freely through dozens of EEZs on its way from China to Europe, but a foreign trawler may not fish in them without permission.

When two EEZs collide, the line is drawn halfway — and disputes follow

When two EEZs overlap, UNCLOS calls for an equidistant line between the coasts, splitting the shared gulf or strait down the middle. EEZs are a stake of power for states: delimiting them can be a source of disputes, even between allies.

EXAMPLE UK–France fishing row, May 2021: two Royal Navy ships and two French vessels patrolled the waters off the British Channel Island of Jersey, as a dispute over post-Brexit fishing licences escalated: under the EU–UK trade deal, French boats had to show a history of fishing in the area to get a licence for Jersey's waters. France threatened to cut off Jersey's electricity, 90% of which comes through three undersea cables from France; the Royal Navy deployed the patrol boats HMS Severn and HMS Tamar.

Beyond the EEZs, the high seas escape almost every law

The high seas (international waters) lie beyond national jurisdiction: no state owns them. Freedom of navigation reigns, but control is weak — illegal fishing, abuses on board, pollution. This is why protecting the high seas has become a diplomatic issue (see II.3).

EXAMPLE Fadhil, a young deckhand, spent a year (2018–2019) on the Chinese squid-fishing ship Wei-Yu 18 in the South Atlantic and off Peru, far from any port; he died of beriberi, a disease of malnutrition, on 26 September 2019 and was buried at sea (video “Death on Chinese fishing ships in high seas”). Video: “Who owns the high seas?” (5 min).

II.2 The maritime choke points

Choke points are narrow, crowded passages on which world trade depends

Maritime choke points are points of congestion on some of the world's famous shipping routes: narrow waterways with high traffic because of their strategic location (key term). They can be natural (straits) or man-made (canals). Should one of them be closed, world trade would be harshly affected: ships would have to take much longer routes.

EXAMPLE On 23 March 2021, the Ever Given, a container ship longer than the Eiffel Tower is tall, was wedged across the Suez Canal by heavy winds and blocked it completely for six days, paralysing trade between Asia and Europe.

Canals: the Suez Canal, a short cut fought over since 1869

The Suez Canal, a 193-km man-made waterway through Egypt, links the Mediterranean to the Red Sea, and so the Atlantic to the Indian Ocean. Opened in 1869, it is the longest canal in the world without locks (13–15 hours to cross), so it can even take aircraft carriers. About 12% of world trade passes through it each year: without it, a supertanker from the Gulf to Europe would sail 6,000 extra miles around Africa's Cape of Good Hope. The Panama Canal, opened in 1914 — 45 years later — and much shorter, links the Pacific and the Atlantic.

EXAMPLE 1.03 billion tons of cargo crossed the canal in 2019, four times more than the Panama Canal. Nasser nationalised it in 1956, which sparked the Suez Crisis and closed it for a year; the 1967 war closed it for eight years. It earned Egypt about $10 billion in 2023; the expansion completed in 2015 doubled its revenue (document study on the Suez Canal). What the canals save, in nautical miles (map by J.-P. Rodrigue): Rotterdam–Singapore 8,440 via Suez against 11,940 round the Cape; Rotterdam–Mumbai 6,374 against 10,667; New York–Los Angeles 4,970 via Panama against 12,350 through the Strait of Magellan; Rotterdam–Los Angeles 7,836 against 13,522; New York–Sydney 9,332 against 12,000.

Straits: the Strait of Malacca, the busiest passage between two oceans

The Strait of Malacca is the shortest shipping channel between the Indian Ocean and the Pacific, linking the Middle East to China, Japan and South Korea. It is a choke point on several scales: world (one third of world trade), regional (East Asia) and national (China's oil). China calls this dependence its main geopolitical choke-point challenge.

EXAMPLE More than 200 vessels a day pass through the strait, carrying 29% of all oil transported by sea and 25% of the world's traded goods. China and Japan rely on it for 80% of their oil imports; about 60% of China's entire oil supply passes through this stretch, one and a half miles wide at its narrowest. The strait is about 940 km long and 3 km wide; vessel transits rose from 55,957 in 2000 to 84,456 in 2017. At its southern end, Singapore is the second container port in the world (33.67 million TEUs), ahead of Port Klang (13th, 11.98 million) and Tanjung Pelepas (19th, 8.38 million) (Alphaliner, 2018). Video: “Why is the Strait of Malacca so Important to the World's Economy & Military” (8 min).

Oil flows through a few choke points: Malacca and Hormuz first

Oil, the first good traded by sea, depends on a few passages. The Strait of Hormuz, the exit of the Persian Gulf, is the most sensitive: about a fifth of the world's oil passes through it every day, and Iran threatens from time to time to close it — in 2023, if the United States directly aided Israel in its war with Hamas, or tightened sanctions on Iran. The strait is watched by the naval bases of Iran's Revolutionary Guards and by the US 5th Fleet, based in Bahrain.

EXAMPLE Daily transit of petroleum in 2023 (U.S. Energy Information Administration, million barrels a day): Strait of Malacca 23.7; Strait of Hormuz 20.9; Suez Canal 8.8; Bab el-Mandeb 8.6; Cape of Good Hope 6; Danish Straits 4.9; Turkish Straits 3.4; Panama Canal 2.1. In 2023, 20.5 million barrels of oil and products passed through Hormuz each day on average (Graphic News). In 2025: Malacca 23.2; Hormuz 20.9; Cape of Good Hope 9.1; Suez Canal 4.9; Danish Straits 4.9; Bab el-Mandeb 4.2; Turkish Straits 3.7; Panama Canal 2.3. Between 2023 and 2025, Suez and Bab el-Mandeb lost about half their oil while the Cape gained half as much again: the Houthi detour, in figures.

Choke points are exposed to wars and attacks, which redraw routes

Because they are narrow, choke points are where conflicts hit trade. Strategic straits attract military bases, piracy and migration, and a crisis can divert the world's ships for years. Shipping companies then choose between risk and cost.

EXAMPLE After the Houthi rebels of Yemen began attacking merchant ships near Bab el-Mandeb in late 2023, the Suez route was largely abandoned for the Cape of Good Hope. CMA CGM led the return to Suez, then, in January 2026, sent three services (FAL 1, FAL 3, MEX) back round the Cape "in light of the complex and uncertain international context". Djibouti, at the mouth of the Red Sea, hosts foreign military bases. Two videos on strategic straits: Djibouti (12 min) and Gibraltar (35 min) — world trade, strategic location, military bases, piracy, and migration at Gibraltar.

Choke points cause tension, but they also force cooperation

User states and neighbouring states do not see a strait in the same way. Users (China, Japan, the USA…) see a strategic axis of the world economy and care about free movement and the safety of their ships (piracy, terrorism). Neighbouring states see an inland sea, fragile, where populations living off the sea are concentrated; they fear that external military powers interfere on the pretext of security, as happened off Somalia. Securing the strait therefore requires cooperation.

EXAMPLE Malaysia, Indonesia and Singapore share the Strait of Malacca and its problems (piracy, pollution, the haze from forest fires). In a war between the USA and China, control of the strait would be vital; China looks for alternatives, but a canal through Thailand's Isthmus of Kra will likely not be dug, because of its disastrous ecological effects.

Piracy threatens shipping near a few coasts

Piracy and armed robbery at sea threaten ships near certain coasts and straits: the Gulf of Guinea, South-East Asia (Indonesia, Singapore, the Philippines) and the Gulf of Aden. Incidents have fallen since their 2011 peak, thanks in part to naval patrols, but they remain numerous.

EXAMPLE Piracy and robbery incidents (French Ministry of the Armed Forces): 439 in 2008, a peak of 668 in 2011, then about 360 to 380 a year from 2016 to 2020 (375 in 2020). Countries with the most incidents: Nigeria 42, Indonesia 37, Singapore 28, Yemen 18, Ghana 16, the Philippines 14, Benin 13, India 11, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines 11, Peru 10. In 2025 (International Maritime Bureau), South-East Asia leads by far — about 90 incidents (the source is hard to read: 85 or 95) — ahead of the Gulf of Guinea (21), the Indian subcontinent (8), off Somalia (8) and the Americas (5).

II.3 The challenge of sustainability

Shipping pollutes, but less per tonne carried than any other transport

The shipping industry accounts for 3% of greenhouse-gas emissions. Sea transport has become more fuel efficient, safer and cheaper, but sustainability can still improve: minimise pollution in ports, for workers and residents; make oil tankers safer to avoid oil spills; develop new green fuels (green methanol, hydrogen); recycle ships. Yet shipping emits far less CO_2 per kg transported than any other means of transport.

EXAMPLE The container ship MV X-Press Pearl caught fire and sank off Colombo, Sri Lanka, in June 2021, spilling chemicals and plastic pellets on the coast. The CMA CGM Notre Dame (2026) runs on liquefied natural gas, less polluting than heavy fuel oil.

Marine protected areas are growing, far from the 30% target

Marine protected areas (MPAs) limit human activities to preserve biodiversity. The COP15 biodiversity conference in Montreal (2022) set the target of protecting 30% of the ocean by 2030. Coverage is growing, but slowly, and protection is often weak: bottom trawling is still allowed in many MPAs.

EXAMPLE The announcements of the UN Ocean Conference in Nice (June 2025) raised global MPA coverage from 8.4% to about 11%, according to French estimates; environmental groups criticised France for offering little immediate restriction on bottom trawling (Le Monde).

The high seas treaty: governing the ocean beyond national jurisdiction

Because the high seas belong to no one, states negotiate to protect them. The BBNJ agreement (Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction), or "high seas treaty", adopted in 2023, allows marine protected areas outside the EEZs; it needed 60 ratifications to come into force. The other battle is deep-sea mining: some states want a moratorium, others want to start extracting.

> **EXAMPLE** At the third UN Ocean Conference (Nice, June 2025: 60 heads of state and government, without the United States), 50 countries had ratified the treaty and about 15 more pledged to; 37 countries called for a moratorium on deep-sea mining, France's position since 2022, while Donald Trump had ordered in April 2025 faster permits to mine in international waters. The treaty reached 60 ratifications in September 2025 and came into force in January 2026.

III.1 The emergence of new shipping routes: the Arctic, the future of seaborne trade?

The Arctic: three routes opened by global warming

The Arctic is the polar region of the Earth that surrounds the North Pole; its snow and ice cover varies with the seasons (key term). Global warming is melting the sea ice and opening new shipping routes, which represent significant challenges and opportunities for the international community. Three routes cross the Arctic: the Northeast Passage (the Northern Sea Route, along Russia), the Northwest Passage (through the Canadian Arctic archipelago) and the Transpolar Sea Route (across the pole, still in the future).

> **EXAMPLE** As the ice diminishes, a region once considered impassable attracts renewed interest: states want the new lanes for shorter transit times, resource extraction, military activity, regional shipping, fishing and tourism (Gabriella Gricius, 2021).

The benefits: shorter routes, resources and the development of remote regions

Arctic routes are a major short cut between Europe, Asia and North America, of great commercial interest, especially for China. The region holds massive reserves of ores and fuels, whose development would boost the growth of the neighbouring countries (Canada, Russia, Norway, the USA). New ports, jobs and cities could develop poor and remote regions and put them at the centre of attention.

> **EXAMPLE** The Northwest Passage could slash shipping times between Europe and Asia by thousands of miles, or as much as two weeks: one of the main reasons Donald Trump took such an interest in Greenland (The Guardian, January 2025).

The constraints: ice, cold, costs and the lack of infrastructure

The Arctic still has many obstacles: unpredictable seas, a severe climate, high costs and a lack of infrastructure. The routes are only open for a short period in late summer, and expensive icebreakers must clear the way for other ships. Along the Northwest Passage there are no big markets and no ports of call to refuel or repair.

> **EXAMPLE** "Come up here and see what you are actually dealing with": for Niels Clemensen, head of Royal Arctic Line, Greenland's only shipping company, the island has no big road network and no trains, so everything travels by sea or air — "it's going to cost a lot of money". For Johanna Ikävalko (Arctic Centre), the Northwest Passage remains "a very risky area for navigating".

From cooperation to competition: sovereignty, crime and militarisation

The Arctic was traditionally a region of cooperation and low tensions; it is increasingly seen as an area of geopolitical competition between the USA, China and Russia. Three concerns: sovereignty (it is unclear who decides who may pass through the new routes, and under what standards); transnational crime (unknown ships may bring illegal fishing or trafficking), which pushes Arctic states, especially Canada and Russia, to control their northern borders, and so to more military presence; and the Russia–China relationship.

> **EXAMPLE** On the Northern Sea Route, China provides funding and technology, Russia provides access: a potential alliance that worries the USA, which may build up its military strength in the Arctic "just in case" (Gricius, 2021).

Icebreakers and Greenland: the new front of power

Owning icebreakers commands access to everything in the Arctic, from shipping routes to search and rescue and minerals: they have become a new front in the competition between the great powers. Russia dominates, with a network of ports and military bases. Greenland, on the route of the Northwest Passage, has become a target.

> **EXAMPLE** Russia has at least 50 icebreakers, at least 13 of which can operate in the Arctic and seven of which are nuclear, and military bases near Murmansk; China has four suited to the Arctic; Denmark, responsible for Greenland's defence, has none since 2010. Trump has not ruled out using military force to get Greenland (The Guardian, 30 January 2025). Video: "Du détroit de Béring à l'Arctique : les ambitions russes" (12 min, January 2025).

A fragile environment and indigenous communities at risk

The opening of the Arctic has potentially irreversible environmental impacts. More carbon emissions in the polar region could accelerate the melting of the sea ice — or stop it: the effects of climate change are unpredictable. The fragile polar ecosystem and indigenous communities could suffer serious disruption, and an oil spill in the ice would be a huge risk.

> **EXAMPLE** Vittus Qujaukitsoq, head of Greenland's association of professional fishers and hunters: icebreakers would help some small fishing boats out to sea, but others think they "would ruin their way of living"; the melting ice and unpredictable weather already affect hunting and fishing in Greenland's rural communities.

III.2 The example of the Northwest Passage

The Northwest Passage: a short cut between the Atlantic and the Pacific, claimed by Canada

The Northwest Passage (NWP) is one of the shipping routes between the Atlantic and Pacific oceans through the Arctic Ocean, along the northern coast of North America, through the Canadian Arctic archipelago — instead of the traditional passage through the Panama Canal. The growth of its traffic is already a reality, because the extent of sea ice is diminishing. Its status is disputed: the Canadian government maintains that the NWP is part of Canadian waters.

> **EXAMPLE** Greenland, on the route of the passage, is likely to play an important role in its future; the United States contests Canada's position and sees the passage as an international strait.

The DBQ answer: benefits on paper, constraints in reality

A model answer to the DBQ "The benefits of the emergence of new maritime routes in the Arctic far outweigh the constraints" weighs both sides. For: a major short cut for seaborne trade (90% of world trade), of commercial interest especially for China; development of poor, remote regions; massive ore and fuel reserves. Against: no big markets and no ports of call on the NWP; contested sovereignty; open only in late summer, with expensive icebreakers; a new gold rush for hydrocarbons and minerals that could raise international tensions; unpredictable effects on the ice; fragile ecosystems and indigenous communities.

> **EXAMPLE** A balanced judgement: the benefits are real but mostly future, while the constraints are present — so the claim that they "far outweigh" them is only partly valid today. (This answer says 90% of world trade; part I says 80% by volume: the figure depends on the source and the measure.)

IV.1 Geopolitical conflict in maritime zones: territorial claims

In the South China Sea, China claims almost everything inside its nine-dash line

China claims historical rights over most of the South China Sea, inside its "nine-dash line". Its claims overlap those of Vietnam, the Philippines, Malaysia, Brunei and Taiwan, over the Paracel and Spratly Islands and Scarborough Shoal; in the East China Sea, China and Japan dispute the Diaoyu/Senkaku Islands. Five maritime entries lead into the South China Sea and East Asia: the Taiwan Strait, the Luzon Strait, the passages through the Philippines, the Strait of Malacca and the Sunda Strait — whoever controls the sea controls the approaches to China.

> **EXAMPLE** Even maps are contested: Vietnam banned Barbie because a map seemed to show the nine-dash line (introduction). On the ground, China has built and militarised artificial islands, such as Fiery Cross Reef in the Spratlys.

The stakes: trade routes, resources and military control

The South China Sea combines every stake of maritime areas: one of the world's busiest trade routes, between the Strait of Malacca and the ports of East Asia; fish; oil and gas; and military control of the approaches to China. Holding islands means claiming EEZs around them, and so their resources.

> **EXAMPLE** In figures: the South China Sea covers roughly 3 million km², lies on lucrative hydrocarbon deposits, is an important source of fish and houses some of the world's biggest coral reefs; more than US$5 trillion of trade passes through the region each year. (Another estimate gives $3.5 trillion through the Strait of Malacca and across the South China Sea: the estimates differ according to the source and what they count — II.2.) China found the 100-million-ton Huizhou 19-6 oilfield in 2025 in the undisputed part of its EEZ (I.2).

The rule of law against the rule of force

International law has ruled against China, but China ignores it. Allowing it to change the situation unilaterally by force would leave the South China Sea governed by the rule of force rather than the rule of law.

> **EXAMPLE** On 12 July 2016, the arbitral tribunal of the South China Sea case, brought by the Philippines, rejected China's nine-dash line. On 21 March 2021, about 220 Chinese fishing vessels — China's maritime militia — moored in military formation in the Philippines' EEZ in the Spratlys, about 175 nautical miles west of Palawan; the Philippines protested but could not remove them (The Diplomat, 2021).

A regional dispute that has become global

The South China Sea is no longer just a regional issue. The countries that oppose China's actions defend the freedom of navigation and the peaceful resolution of disputes in a "Free and Open Indo-Pacific", and European navies join them.

> **EXAMPLE** The Free and Open Indo-Pacific Strategy is put forward by the Quad — Japan, the United States, Australia and India; the United Kingdom, France and Germany have taken part in joint military exercises based on it (Sakamoto Shigeki, The Diplomat, 2021).

Maritime borders can also be settled by agreement

Disputes over maritime borders are not always conflicts without end: delimiting EEZs can open the way to cooperation and to the shared exploitation of resources, even between enemies.

> **EXAMPLE** Israel and Lebanon, two countries technically at war, reached an agreement in 2022 that ended a long dispute over their maritime border in the Mediterranean: Israel keeps full rights to develop the Karish gas field, Lebanon full rights in Qana, opening the door to offshore energy exploration. On the map, Lebanon's formal claim (Line 23) and its maximalist claim (Line 29) overlap Israel's line; the agreement follows Line 23, and Lebanon's Block 9, around Qana, was licensed to Eni, Total and Novatek.

IV.2 Sea power

Sea power: using the seas, protecting oneself, destroying the enemy's fleet

Sea power is the capacity to use the seas for various purposes, including protection from enemy attack and the capacity to destroy the enemy's fleet, commercial and military. Sea power also allows a state to bombard land objectives from the sea. Aircraft carriers and submarines have increased the strategic importance of sea power.

> **EXAMPLE** The US Navy alone has 11 aircraft carriers, 66 submarines, 73 destroyers and 340,000 active personnel, with a base budget of $244 billion for the Navy and Marines in 2023 (Council on Foreign Relations).

A maritime power controls its coasts and projects influence far away

A maritime power is able to control its coast and to exert influence upon both nearby and far countries (key term). A navy has "command of the sea" when it is so strong that its rivals cannot attack it directly. Overseas bases allow a navy to be present on every ocean.

> **EXAMPLE** The US Navy's forward deployed bases ring the world: Rota (Spain), Naples and Sigonella (Italy), Souda Bay (Greece), Bahrain, Djibouti, Diego Garcia, Singapore, Guam, Okinawa, Sasebo and Yokosuka (Japan), Chinhae (South Korea), Pearl Harbor and Guantanamo Bay.

A hierarchy of navies dominated by the USA, with China rising

The hierarchy of sea powers is very unequal: the United States far ahead, then Russia and China, then Japan, the United Kingdom, France and India. China's sea power is growing fast, with its navy and its artificial islands, which challenges American command of the seas of East Asia.

> **EXAMPLE** The world's largest navies by tonnage: United States 3,415,893 t; Russia 845,730; China 708,886; Japan 413,800; United Kingdom 367,850; France 319,195; India 317,725; South Korea 178,710; Italy 173,549; Taiwan 151,662. Video: "Chinese sea power" (12 min).

V.1 The aspects of French maritime power

Present on every ocean, through its overseas territories and its power projection

What makes a maritime power? First, presence on every ocean. France has it in two ways: through its overseas territories, scattered across the Atlantic, the Indian Ocean and the Pacific, and through power projection — naval bases abroad and an aircraft carrier able to sail anywhere.

> **EXAMPLE** Overseas territories on three oceans: the Antilles, French Guiana and Saint-Pierre-and-Miquelon (Atlantic); Réunion, Mayotte, the Scattered Islands and the French Southern Lands (Indian Ocean); New Caledonia, French Polynesia, Wallis-and-Futuna and Clipperton (Pacific). Bases abroad: Djibouti and Abu Dhabi.

A navy of the first rank: nuclear aircraft carrier and nuclear submarines

France has a navy of the first rank. It is the only power, with the United States, to have a nuclear-powered aircraft carrier. It has four ballistic missile submarines (SSBNs, "sous-marins nucléaires lanceurs d'engins") — like the United States, Russia, the United Kingdom, China and India — which carry nuclear deterrence, and five attack submarines.

> **EXAMPLE** The aircraft carrier Charles de Gaulle was used in Libya in 2011. The nuclear attack submarine Suffren, inaugurated in July 2019 and tested at sea from April 2020, is the first of a new generation, built at Cherbourg, a shipyard specialised in military vessels. By tonnage, the French navy is the sixth in the world (319,195 t, IV.2).

A merchant navy embodied by CMA CGM — French by its headquarters more than by its ships

France has a world-class shipping company, CMA CGM, the third container shipping company in the world, whose headquarters is in Marseille. But it is French by its headquarters and decision centres much more than by the flag of its ships, its crews or its capital: globalisation blurs the nationality of shipping.

> **EXAMPLE** The CMA CGM tower dominates the port of Marseille. The company's ships, like the CMA CGM Notre Dame, are built in China, and many sail under other flags (I.1).

Shipyards in decline, except for the giants of cruise ships and warships

French shipbuilding has declined to the benefit of Asian shipyards (South Korea, then China). It survives in niches of excellence: very large cruise ships and military vessels.

> **EXAMPLE** The Chantiers de l'Atlantique at Saint-Nazaire, one of the world's largest shipyards, specialise in cruise ships: more than 3,000 employees build the biggest cruise ships in the world. Cherbourg builds submarines such as the Suffren.

The resources of the sea: fishing, energy and minerals

French maritime power also rests on the resources of the sea: fishing, energy and minerals. France has major fishing ports on the Channel and the Atlantic, but few offshore fossil-fuel reserves.

> **EXAMPLE** Boulogne-sur-Mer and Lorient are the leading French fishing ports.

66 ports, but none among the world's giants, and far from the Northern Range

France has 66 ports. Marseille and Le Havre are the two main ones, but few French ports are connected to the European "maritime façade" of the Northern Range, which lies to the north (Antwerp, Rotterdam). French ports remain modest by world standards.

> **EXAMPLE** Marseille and Le Havre are only the 53rd and 68th ports in the world by tonnage.

The maritime economy: 2.5% of GDP and 300,000 direct jobs

Maritime power is also an economy. An infographic counts about 300,000 direct jobs and 2.5% of France's GDP. Fishing and sea products employ the most people, ahead of shipbuilding, boating, ports, defence, oil and maritime transport; the activities of the future — marine renewable energies, mineral resources — still weigh very little. France is the 3rd European country for fishing, but it imports much more seafood than it exports.

> **EXAMPLE** Direct jobs: fishing, aquaculture, sea products and biotechnologies 64,823; shipbuilding and naval activities 42,000; recreational boating 40,166; commercial ports 39,000; defence and state action at sea 30,000; oil 29,000; maritime transport 22,000; marine renewable energies only 800 and marine mineral resources 700. The French eat 34 kg of seafood per person per year; imports reach €6 billion against €1.6 billion of exports (Mer et Marine, 2017, and gouvernement.fr, 2018).

V.2 Geostrategic stakes

Appropriating the sea: the second largest EEZ in the world

Thanks to its overseas territories, France has an EEZ of about 10.7 million km², the second in the world, which explains how it can claim to be "the second maritime power in the world". 62% of the French EEZ lies in the Pacific; French Polynesia alone accounts for 40%. Enlarging the EEZ is a territorial stake: the EXTRAPLAC programme asks for the extension of the continental shelf. The question is the appropriation of the resources of the sea: fishing, and potential seabed minerals and energy.

> **EXAMPLE** The French EEZ even includes the first shipping route in the world, which links Northern Europe to Asia through Gibraltar and the Suez Canal (in the Channel and the Mediterranean). (Video: "Comment la France peut-elle être la 2e puissance maritime mondiale ?", 4 min.)

Controlling and securing maritime space: naval bases on every ocean

France has naval bases on every ocean: overseas (Martinique, French Guiana, Réunion, New Caledonia, French Polynesia), in the mainland (Toulon, Brest, Cherbourg) and abroad (Djibouti, Abu Dhabi). Securing its maritime space means renewing equipment — a military and a financial stake —, adapting to a new world geopolitics (the pivot towards Asia), fighting piracy and watching over a huge EEZ.

> **EXAMPLE** The Toulon arsenal is the most active today, because it is close to the theatres of operation, especially the Middle East: it is the home port of the aircraft carrier Charles de Gaulle and of the nuclear attack submarines. France takes part in Operation Atalanta against piracy, and watches over its EEZ as far as Wallis-and-Futuna (video, 3 min). The map of French maritime power sums up the logic of this part: control the world's maritime space (bases, submarines on patrol), secure it (the world shipping route, the routes between French territories, the raw material supply areas of West Africa and the Arabian Peninsula), appropriate it (the EEZ and its extension requests).

New energy stakes: securing supplies by sea, developing marine renewables

France has no significant offshore fossil-fuel reserves, but the EEZ of the Scattered Islands (in the Mozambique Channel) is promising for gas. The real stake is to secure energy supplies by sea. Marine renewable energies are a potential to develop.

> **EXAMPLE** The French company Total is the first gas operator in Africa and is developing the huge gas reserves discovered off Mozambique.

Modernising the ports to stay competitive

Modernisation projects, financed by the State and local authorities, aim to keep French ports competitive in globalisation and to diversify their activities (cruise tourism). The State also maintains naval military-industrial complexes.

> **EXAMPLE** Fos 4XL, the extension of the container terminals of Marseille-Fos. The military-industrial complexes of Brest, Cherbourg and Toulon.

V.3 Managing maritime spaces — and the verdict

Protecting the sea: protected areas and a constitutional ambition

With about 4,000 km of coastline and an EEZ of nearly 11 million km², France has a special responsibility for protecting the sea. Protected areas preserve fragile coasts and seabeds.

> **EXAMPLE** The Scandola nature reserve in southern Corsica is a protected space. In July 2018, MPs voted to write the preservation of the seas and oceans into Article 34 of the Constitution, showing how much protecting its maritime spaces matters for France. (The constitutional reform that carried this amendment was in fact never completed.)

A network of marine protected areas: 23.5% of French waters in 2019

France has built a dense network of marine protected areas (MPAs), the tool already met at world level in part II.3. It grew very fast — especially in 2014 — and it lies mostly overseas, because almost all the French maritime space is there.

> **EXAMPLE** An infographic (French Ministry for the Ecological Transition, July 2019): 0.3% of French waters protected in 2006, 0.8% in 2009, 3.8% in 2013, 16.3% in 2014, 23.5% in July 2019, with 546 marine protected areas in mainland France and overseas. France is the 2nd maritime space in the world (over 10 million km²), and 97% of it is overseas. (The jump of 2014 comes from the Natural Park of the Coral Sea, created around New Caledonia.)

Summary of the theme: maritime areas in globalisation

The theme closes with a summary map in three parts, which is also a ready-made plan. 1) A space of circulation: maritime highways between the three centres of the world economy, secondary routes, alternative Arctic routes as the pack ice melts, maritime façades. 2) Economic stakes: fishing grounds, offshore oil and gas fields, major ports — mostly Chinese — and the states with the largest maritime domains. 3) Strategic stakes: strategic passages, piracy zones, rivalries between coastal states over resources (the Arctic, the South China Sea).

> **EXAMPLE** On the summary map, the top three states by maritime domain are the United States, the United Kingdom and France, and the five leading states by fishing volume are China, Indonesia, Peru, Russia and the United States. The major ports are Rotterdam, Dubai, Singapore, Busan and the Chinese ports (Shanghai, Ningbo, Qingdao, Tianjin, Qinhuangdao, Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Hong Kong). Each part sends back to the chapter: parts I and II for circulation and resources, III and IV for the Arctic and the rivalries, V for France. (Other rankings of EEZs put Australia and Russia ahead of the United Kingdom.)

The verdict: a great maritime power, between power and fear of decline

Is France a great maritime power? Yes, through its EEZ (second in the world), its presence on every ocean, its navy (nuclear carrier and submarines) and its world-class companies and shipyards. But its ports are middle-ranking, its shipbuilding has declined, its equipment is costly to renew, and its maritime space is mostly made of distant territories. France stands "between power and fear of decline".

> **EXAMPLE** A closing video: "La France, entre puissance et peur du déclin" (Le Dessous des cartes, 12 min). Strength: 10.7 million km² of EEZ; weakness: Marseille only 53rd port in the world.

Bac At the exam: the 2025 essay on maritimisation

The June 2025 question asked you to weigh maritimisation against the other factors

In June 2025, the geography essay of subject B asked: "Maritimisation is the most important factor in the organisation of the global economy." Assess the validity of this statement. To assess is to weigh: first show how maritimisation organises the global economy (seaborne trade, containerisation, ports, choke points, resources, cables), then confront it with other factors (TNCs and global value chains, states' policies and the law of the sea, finance, air and land transport, digital networks), and give a clear judgement.

> **EXAMPLE** This document study gives two real anonymised scripts of this exam to assess (copies 2-040 and 2-048). The site's reading of them is below: it is not an official marking.

Key figures

Ban Ki-moon
UN Secretary-General: "maritime transport is the backbone of global trade" (2016)

Jacques Saadé
Founder of CMA CGM (1978), France's leading container shipping company

Rodolphe Saadé
Chairman and CEO of CMA CGM, who wants it to be the world's second shipping line by 2027

Gamal Abdel Nasser
Egyptian president who nationalised the Suez Canal in 1956

Xi Jinping
Chinese president, at the inauguration of the Chinese-owned port of Chancay (Peru, 2024)

Nathalie Fau
Geographer: users and neighbours do not see the Strait of Malacca the same way

Gabriella Gricius
Researcher in Arctic politics: the Arctic shifts from cooperation to competition (2021)

Niels Clemensen
Head of Royal Arctic Line, Greenland's only shipping company

Johanna Ikävalko
Director of the Arctic Centre: "the world order will start to evolve from the Arctic"

Vittus Qujaukitsoq
Head of Greenland's fishers' and hunters' association

Donald Trump
US president who wants Greenland

Sakamoto Shigeki
Japanese professor: the South China Sea has become a global issue (2021)

Numbers

80%
Share of world trade (by volume) carried by sea

24,000 TEUs
Capacity of the CMA CGM Notre Dame (2026), 399 m long

1 in 10
Containers of the world handled in the Yangtze River Delta

50 million TEUs
Shanghai's throughput in 2024, a world first

30%
Share of world oil and gas produced offshore

200 nautical miles
Width of an EEZ (UNCLOS, 1982)

12%
Share of world trade through the Suez Canal

29% / 25%
Shares of seaborne oil and of traded goods through the Strait of Malacca

23.7 / 20.9
Million barrels of oil a day through Malacca and Hormuz (2023)

3%
Shipping's share of greenhouse-gas emissions

30% by 2030
Target for protecting the ocean (COP15, 2022); about 11% in 2025

3
Arctic routes: Northeast Passage, Northwest Passage, Transpolar Sea Route

2 weeks
Time the Northwest Passage could save between Europe and Asia

50+ / 7
Russian icebreakers, of which seven are nuclear

0
Icebreakers of Denmark, in charge of Greenland's defence, since 2010

220
Chinese militia vessels in the Philippines' EEZ, March 2021

11
Aircraft carriers of the US Navy

3.4 Mt
Tonnage of the US Navy, four times Russia's

10.7 million km²
French EEZ, the second in the world

62% / 40%
Shares of the French EEZ in the Pacific / in French Polynesia alone

1
Nuclear-powered aircraft carrier — only France and the USA have one

4 + 5
Ballistic missile submarines + attack submarines

3rd
Rank of CMA CGM among the world's container shipping companies

3,000+
Employees of the Chantiers de l'Atlantique, builders of the biggest cruise ships

66
French ports

53rd / 68th
World ranks of Marseille and Le Havre by tonnage

4,000 km
Coastline of France (one common estimate)

2.5%
Share of the maritime economy in French GDP (about 300,000 direct jobs)

23.5%
Share of French waters covered by a marine protected area (July 2019; 546 MPAs)

97%
Share of the French maritime space located overseas

Vocabulary

TRADE AND TRANSPORT

Globalisation
Growing interconnection of people, companies and governments worldwide (key term).

Maritimisation
The growing role of the sea in the economy, and the concentration of people and activities on coasts.

Containerisation
Use of standard metal boxes moved from ship to truck to train (key term).

TEU
Twenty-foot equivalent unit: the measure of a container ship's capacity.

Gigantism
The race to ever bigger ships to cut the cost of each container.

Hub
Major port where cargo is concentrated and transhipped between lines.

Hinterland / foreland
The land area a port serves / the overseas markets it connects to.

Global value chain
Production split into stages located in different countries.

NIDL
New International Division of Labour: headquarters in the North, factories near ports in the South.

Thalassocracy
A power whose strength rests on the sea (said of China's port range).

RESOURCES

Capture fisheries / aquaculture
Wild fishing / fish farming.

Overfishing
Fishing faster than stocks can renew themselves.

Bottom trawling
Dragging a net along the seabed, which destroys it.

Offshore
At sea: offshore oil and gas fields, offshore wind farms.

Polymetallic nodules
Lumps on the deep seabed rich in nickel, cobalt, copper and rare earths.

Marine renewable energies
Offshore wind, tidal, wave and ocean thermal energy.

THE LAW OF THE SEA AND CHOKE POINTS

UNCLOS
UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (1982).

Territorial waters
12 nautical miles of full sovereignty.

Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ)
200 nautical miles where the coastal state controls resources (key term).

High seas
International waters, beyond national jurisdiction.

Maritime choke point
Narrow, crowded strait or canal on a major route (key term).

Strait / canal
Natural / man-made passage between two seas.

Piracy
Attacks and robbery against ships at sea.

Marine protected area (MPA)
Sea area where human activities are limited to protect biodiversity.

BBNJ
The high seas treaty (2023): biodiversity beyond national jurisdiction.

NEW ROUTES

The Arctic
Polar region around the North Pole, with seasonal ice cover (key term).

Northern Sea Route
Arctic route along the Russian coast (Northeast Passage).

Northwest Passage
Arctic route through the Canadian archipelago, claimed by Canada.

Transpolar Sea Route
Future route straight across the pole.

Icebreaker
Ship that clears a way through the ice.

Sea ice
Frozen sea water, shrinking with global warming.

CONFLICT AND POWER AT SEA

Nine-dash line
China's claim over most of the South China Sea, rejected in 2016.

Arbitration
Settlement of a dispute by a tribunal (the Philippines v. China, 2016).

Maritime militia
Fishing boats used as a paramilitary force (China).

Freedom of navigation
The right of all ships to sail on the high seas and through straits.

Sea power
Capacity to use the seas, protect oneself and destroy the enemy's fleet.

Maritime power
A state able to control its coast and exert influence near and far (key term).

Command of the sea
Naval superiority so great that rivals cannot attack directly.

Power projection
Ability to send forces far away (carriers, overseas bases).

FRENCH MARITIME POWER

Overseas territories
French territories outside Europe, on three oceans, which make the EEZ.

SSBN
Ballistic missile submarine: carries nuclear deterrence.

SSN
Nuclear attack submarine (the Suffren).

Nuclear deterrence
Preventing attack by the threat of nuclear retaliation.

Arsenal
Naval base and shipyard of the navy (Toulon, Brest, Cherbourg).

Flag
The nationality under which a ship is registered.

EXTRAPLAC
French programme to extend the continental shelf beyond 200 nautical miles.

Operation Atalanta
European naval operation against piracy off Somalia.

Maritime façade
A coastline lined with major ports and their hinterland, open to world trade (the Northern Range).